

International AS and A-level Psychology (9685) PS04 Approaches and Application Report on the examination

June 2024

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY (9685) PS04 JUNE 2024

Performance on this exam was comparable with previous series, with some students demonstrating excellent psychological knowledge and understanding. Overall, students performed better on questions requiring AO1 skills with AO2 and AO3 skills steadily improving. In application questions most students could identify the psychology within the stem, and some could use that psychology to interpret and explain the material within it. Evaluation/discussion is improving with most students offering well informed and effective arguments. In terms of content, Approaches and Issues and Debates in Psychology were well prepared. Work and the Individual, however, was not well prepared. This was evidenced by some very common sense/anecdotal answers being offered in place of well-learned knowledge and understanding. It would be prudent for students to spend time thoroughly preparing this section to avoid losing marks.

Extended response questions provide the most diversity across the paper. The best responses take account of the likely split of marks by assessment objective. For example, better answers to 12-mark questions with a stem are written by students who understand that, following application, there is likely only room for two or three well-written discussion/evaluation points in the time given to answer the question. Extended response questions where students are asked to apply knowledge from topics they have studied are answered well and the content is appropriately used. However, far too many students are relying on the topic of schizophrenia to answer a number of different questions within the paper, and this is to be avoided. Finally, on extended response questions, students must ensure they regularly check in with the original question title. For example, some of the extended response answers on the biological approach became an answer to 'describe and evaluate the biological approach to schizophrenia', which achieved little credit. Some handwriting was indecipherable, and centres are kindly asked to ensure that student responses are legible to avoid losing marks.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered well by most students with almost all able to achieve one mark for stating that children in group one will be more likely to show helping behaviour. Stronger students gained full marks explaining that this was because the adult had provided an observable role model by praising them for helping and the strongest could name this as learning by *vicarious reinforcement*.

QUESTION 02

Many students performed well on this question, gaining the two marks available. The main issue for some was responding appropriately to the command word 'briefly' which should elicit a point followed by a brief explanation eg 'That the approach has a useful practical application because it has led to social changes such as age restrictions on films and computer games.'

QUESTION 03

This question was generally well answered with most students responding with a strength and a limitation of the behaviourist approach. Better answers offered a 'point, evidence, explain' format

which worked well within the time limit and the marks available. Weaker responses evaluated studies such as those by Pavlov and Skinner without linking them back to the approach, gaining little credit.

QUESTION 04

There was a varied response to this question with the full range of marks being awarded. The most successful students introduced the biological approach in terms of genes, neurotransmitters, evolution, and biological structures. They were able to describe each feature and explain its role in behaviour eg the frontal cortex being responsible for decision making, planning and moral reasoning. They were able to link these well to topics, such as the evolutionary theory of sleep or the role of neurotransmitters in schizophrenia, and then to discuss the strengths and weaknesses of the biological approach. Weaker responses spent too long on application (4 marks of AO2) and/or lost focus on the question. For example, a significant number of students discussed explanations for schizophrenia rather than discussing the biological approach and, therefore, gained little credit.

QUESTION 05

Almost all students gained the multiple-choice mark for this question, understanding that recording the time taken to recall a word list without bias or emotion was referring to objectivity.

QUESTION 06

Most students were able to provide a correct definition for the term replicability, understanding that it meant experiments could be repeated with similar findings.

QUESTION 07

Many students found this question difficult because of a misconception that the terms 'empirical method' and 'scientific method' were interchangeable, for example, offering strengths that focused on broader themes such as theory construction and hypothesis testing rather than on direct, objective, quantitative observation. Better answers offered a brief strength and/or a limitation explaining that measurement via direct observation increased validity but that taking behaviour out of its social context decreased ecological validity.

QUESTION 08

Most students could gain one mark for explaining that nature was about heredity and nurture was about learning from the environment. Those scoring two marks referred effectively to the debate which was about the 'extent to which' these affect behaviour.

QUESTION 09

This question was well answered with many students gaining 3 of the 4 AO2 marks available. Students are doing much better with this type of question in which they must apply psychological knowledge to explain a short scenario. Many were able to explain that Jack's view was a reductionist one because his idea about explaining human behaviour by studying individual chemicals and processes in the body was like trying to explain a cake by describing the nature of eggs or flour alone. Similarly, they knew that a cake was greater than the sum of its parts, being different from any of the ingredients that went in to make it.

QUESTION 10

Most students were able to gain 2 of the 4 marks available for this question. The main barrier to achieving full marks was failure to explain why the point they had made was a strength or a limitation. For example, many were able to say that reductionism breaks down behaviour into smaller components but failed to explain that this made it easier to study in a controlled way. Similarly, they could explain that behaviour was over-simplified but not that, being taken out of its social context meant that the meaning behind the behaviour was lost. In general, reductionism is poorly understood by many students.

QUESTION 11

This extended response question was well answered by many students although a significant number seem to think that determinism means that behaviour is pre-determined, before birth. This is a misconception which needs to be addressed. Most could offer different types of determinism (eg hard and soft) and many understood that behaviour could be caused by biological and/or environmental factors. On 12-mark questions application marks are minimal so, in this case, it was sufficient to name the type of determinism Mei and Sophie were describing and then give a brief example using the conversation in the stem. Similarly, many students wrote too much for discussion, already gaining the 4 marks available for AO3 after two well developed points. It would be useful to practise breaking down questions by skills so that students have a good idea of how much is sufficient to write while still producing a good response.

QUESTION 12

Most students could achieve one of the two marks available by writing that workplace stress was anxiety caused by the workplace or caused by high job demands and little control. A few could go on to explain that this led to mental and physical health issues.

QUESTION 13

The response to this question was disappointing, with too many students not able to gain half of the six AO2 marks available. Far too many did not know need theory well enough and therefore tended to use any theory of motivation which gained little credit. Better answers focused on Maslow's hierarchy of needs eg linking Paulo's physical needs to adequate pay and a good work environment; and his self-actualisation needs to choosing his own menu and cooking his own food. Similarly, some students used intrinsic and extrinsic needs which also gained credit. Students should ensure that they can name and describe the different motivation theories detailed in the specification so that they are well prepared to answer specific questions on them.

QUESTION 14

Once again, there was a disappointing performance on this question with many students ill prepared to link social identity theory, deindividuation and in-group out-group effects to the scenario. This led to common sense anecdotal answers, largely from own experience, which gained very few marks. Students who did know these theories found it relatively straightforward to claim all the 6 AO2 marks by linking their knowledge to the scenario eg that company B would view company A as the out-group and therefore see them as inferior and this is why they would not want to play for their team.

QUESTION 15

This question was well answered with many students gaining the 4 AO3 marks available by offering two well-informed strengths of the JDR model.

QUESTION 16

Unfortunately, too many students misunderstood this question and wrote about cultural differences in facial expression rather than cultural universals. Stronger responses offered the idea that all cultures could recognise six basic emotions, eg disgust and anger, because they were important for survival and therefore were biological in origin rather than cultural. Ekman's (1987) cross cultural study was offered to support for this idea but, too often, discussion focused on methodological criticisms of the study without explaining why this might be a problem for the idea of universality, thereby losing focus on the question.